

TEXTURE CONTROL — FROM THIN TO THICK

Professional players don't just use more notes — they move freely across the texture spectrum with intention.

← THIN / Advanced

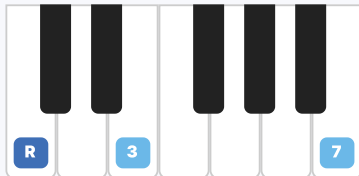
FULL / Rich →

STOP 1 — THIN

Guide Tones

R · 3 · 7

3 notes



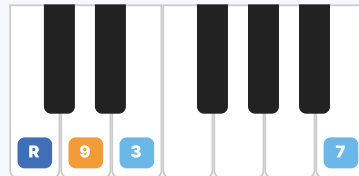
Cmaj7 bare

STOP 2

Guide + Tension

R · 3 · 7 · T

4 notes



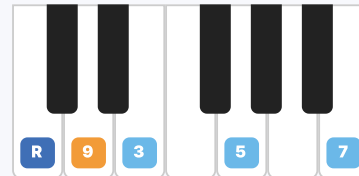
Cmaj9

STOP 3

Full + Tension

R · 3 · 5 · 7 · T

5 notes



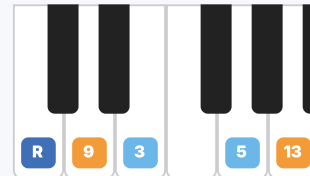
Cmaj9 full

STOP 4 — FULL

Extended

R · 3 · 5 · 7 · 9 · 13

6+ notes



Cmaj13

SIMPLE ≠ BEGINNER

Using **3-note guide tones** is not beginner playing — it's an advanced choice. Bill Evans played thin. Keith Jarrett plays thin when he wants space. Only using thick chords shows you don't yet control your texture.

THE INTERMEDIATE PLATEAU

Most intermediate pianists default to full chords all the time. **Fluency means moving freely** across the spectrum based on musical intention — not defaulting to maximum notes. Thin texture = open, spacious, modern. Thick = full, complete, rich.

THE REAL SKILL

Advanced players don't just use **MORE notes**. They **control how thin or thick the texture is in real time** based on emotional intention. A sparse two-bar phrase with thin guide tones, followed by a full chord with a 13th, creates contrast and drama. Knowing when to use each — that's the skill.